savings from a coupon is guaranteed to go directly to the consumer using it. A coupon can allow a consumer to purchase brand-name products at the same, or sometimes even a lower price, than a store brand. And only the coupon-using consumer obtains those benefits. In fact, there are detractors who insist that the coupon user reaps a benefit that serves to increase the prices across the board. Former Grocery Marketing magazine associate publisher Ryan Mathews, was quoted in the November 8, 1992, *Los Angeles Times* as saying couponing is a “Stone Age industry in a high-tech world, one in which manufacturers have run amok by flooding consumers with tons of worthless paper.” He asserted that in order to pay for the coupons, product makers merely raise prices, helping a select number of people at the expense of the majority. “No company believes that a fraction of these coupons will be redeemed. In fact, if people redeemed even half of the coupons there wouldn’t be enough money in the Treasury to pay for it. The economy would collapse.”

As far back as the late 1970s, Presidential Advisor of Consumer Affairs Esther Peterson had criticized coupons as a cost-increasing form of promotion. Her former employer, Giant Foods of Washington, DC, even produced a film in 1979 that was critical of food coupons. Not surprising, Peterson’s criticism was not taken kindly by proponents of coupons and staunch members of coupon clubs.

There is also the camp of coupon detractors who insist that clipping coupons is a complete waste of a consumer’s time. In the Summer 1982 issue of the *Journal of Consumer Affairs*, J. N. Uhl, Associate Professor of Agricultural Economics at Purdue University, attempted to prove this point.